

IDENTIFYING LANGUAGE



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Although we know language and the ‘appropriate terms’ are ever-changing, the language we use to describe a person who lives with a disability can shape our attitudes and perceptions about them. There are two distinctive forms of identifying language: Person-First and Identity First.

Person First Language puts the person before the disability. It does not make the disability the first thing we know about that person. It tells us that he or she lives with a disability or uses a mobility device such as a wheelchair. Identity First Language puts the disability first, and is preferred by many people in the Autistic, Deaf, and Blind communities. If you are uncertain how to identify someone, just ask them what they prefer.

SAY THIS	INSTEAD OF
<i>Sue has a disability</i>	Sue is disabled, handicapped or differently abled
<i>Jason uses a wheelchair</i>	Jason is wheelchair bound, confined to a wheelchair
<i>David has Down syndrome</i>	David is a Downs kid
<i>Bridget has a physical disability</i>	Bridget is crippled or physically challenged/disabled
<i>Mark is hard of hearing</i>	Mark is hearing impaired
<i>Laura has a vision impairment</i>	Laura is visually impaired
<i>Toby has cerebral palsy</i>	Toby is a victim of or stricken with cerebral palsy
<i>Ann has a traumatic brain injury</i>	Ann is brain damaged
<i>Cheryl does not speak, uses a communication device</i>	Cheryl is dumb or mute
<i>People without disabilities</i>	Normal, healthy, typical people

Information to know about

Disability vs. Special Needs: It is well known that the Rebbe recommended the terminology “Metzuyanim – Exceptional” in the 1970’s when referring to people with disabilities.

While many organizations and educational programs currently use the term “special needs,” especially when referring to children, many people in the disability community are concerned that it generates pity and patronization, and perpetuates the idea that people with “special needs” require special care, special programs, or special services, which is often not the case. The term “disability” is regarded by the disability community to be non-judgmental and factual without promoting notions of pity or heroism and without any judgment attached to it – positive or negative.

Bottom Line: The evolution of language is constantly changing and being reevaluated. The bottom line is not to define a person by their disability unless that is how they choose to be defined. When in doubt #JUSTASK.